

3.1.6 Judaism

Students should be aware that Judaism is one of the diverse religious traditions and beliefs in Great Britain today and that the main religious tradition in Great Britain is Christianity. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should study the beliefs, teachings and practices of Judaism specified below and their basis in Jewish sources of wisdom and authority. They should be able to refer to scripture and/or sacred texts where appropriate. Some texts are prescribed for study in the content set out below and questions may be set on them. Students may refer to any relevant text in their answers and AQA will publish a list of appropriate texts as part of the supporting material for this specification. These additional texts will not be required for study, alternatives may be used, and questions will not be set on them.

Students should study the influence of the beliefs, teachings and practices studied on individuals, communities and societies.

Common and divergent views within Judaism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout. Students may refer to a range of different Jewish perspectives in their answers, for example, Orthodox, Reform and Liberal Judaism. They must study the specific differences identified below.

3.1.6.1 Beliefs and teachings

Key beliefs

- The nature of God:
 - God as one
 - God as Creator
 - God as Law-Giver and Judge, loving and merciful.
- The divine presence (Shekhinah).
- Beliefs about life after death, including judgement and resurrection.
- The nature and role of the Messiah, including different views on the role and importance of the Messiah.

The Covenant and the mitzvot

- The promised land and the Covenant with Abraham, Genesis 12:1-3.
- The Covenant at Sinai and its importance including the role of Moses and the Ten Commandments, Exodus 20:1-17.
- Key moral principles including justice, healing the world, charity and kindness to others.
- The importance of the sanctity of human life, including the concept of 'saving a life' (Pikuach Nefesh).
- The relationship between free will and the 613 mitzvot.

- Mitzvot between man and God and mitzvot between man and man, including the difference between them and their importance.

3.1.6.2 Practices

The synagogue and worship

- The synagogue and its importance.
- The design and religious features of synagogues including bimah (reading platform), aron hakodesh (ark), ner tamid (ever burning light) and associated practices; differences between Orthodox and Reform synagogues.
- Public acts of worship including:
 - synagogue services in both Orthodox and Reform synagogues
 - the significance of prayer, including the Amidah, the standing prayer.
- Shabbat in the home and synagogue and its significance.
- Worship in the home and private prayer.
- Tenakh (the written law) and Talmud (the oral law), and their study, use and significance in daily life.

Family life and festivals

- Rituals and their significance:
 - ceremonies associated with birth including Brit Milah.
 - Bar and Bat Mitzvah
 - the marriage ceremony
 - mourning rituals.
- Dietary laws and their significance, including different Jewish views about their importance.
 - kosher and trefah
 - separation of milk and meat.
- Festivals and their importance for Jews in Great Britain today, including the origins and meaning of:
 - Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur
 - Pesach.